

Gaia Ghirardi

Curriculum Vitae

WZB Berlin Social Science Center
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RESEARCH INTERESTS

social stratification, family sociology, sociogenomics, educational and health inequality

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

- 2026 - Present **Postdoctoral Researcher**
WZB Berlin Social Science Center (Skill Formation and Labor Markets)
Einstein Center Population Diversity (ECPD)
- 2025 - 2026 **Postdoctoral Researcher**
University of Bologna, Department of Statistical Sciences “Paolo Fortunati”
Project: Genes, genealogies and the evolution of demographic change and social inequality (GENPOP)

EDUCATION

- 2020 - 2025 **Ph.D. Social and Political Sciences**
European University Institute (EUI), Florence
Thesis: “Interaction of Family Socioeconomic Status and Genotype in the Intergenerational Transmission of Educational and Health Inequalities”
Advisor: Fabrizio Bernardi
Committee: Nicola Barban, Juho Härkönen, Melinda Mills
★ *ECSR Best PhD Thesis Prize 2026*
- 2017 - 2020 **M.A. Sociology** (*with distinction*)
University of Trento & University of Bamberg - *Double degree program*
Advisors: Moris Triventi, Corinna Kleinert, Tina Baier
- 2014 - 2017 **B.A. Sociology** (*with distinction*)
University of Milano-Bicocca
Advisor: Maurizio Pisati

RESEARCH STAYS

- July 2026 - Aug 2026 **University of Florence, Italy**
Visiting Postdoctoral Researcher - Host: Marco Cozzani
- Sep 2025 - Dec 2025 **UCL Social Research Institute, University College London**
Visiting Postdoctoral Researcher - Host: Per Engzell
- Feb 2025 - May 2025 **University of Oxford, LCDS**
Visiting Postdoctoral Researcher - Host: Melinda Mills
- Sept 2023 - May 2024 **Universidad Nacional de Educación a Distancia (UNED), Madrid**
Visiting PhD Student - Host: Fabrizio Bernardi
- May 2023 **University of Bologna, Italy**
Visiting PhD Student - Host: Nicola Barban
- Sept 2022 - Dec 2023 **Institut National d’Etudes Démographiques (INED), Paris**
Center for Research in Economics and Statistics (CREST), Paris
Visiting PhD Student - Hosts: Lidia Panico & Felix Tropf

GRANTS

- 2027* – 2029 **Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellowship (PI) (€260,347)**
IneqGen, Awarded by Horizon Europe
Host institution: University of Oxford, LCDS
- 2023 **INED Visiting PhD Student Fellowship** (Paris, France)
- 2023 **EUI Early Stage Researchers (ESR) (PI)**
[GxE interaction and educational inequalities](#)
- 2019 **Double-Degree Scholarship**
University of Trento
- 2016 **Merit-Based Scholarship**
University of Milano Bicocca

* September 2027: scheduled start of the MSCA

AWARDS

- 2026 **ECSR PhD Dissertation Prize**
[2026 Best PhD Thesis Prize, European Consortium for Sociological Research \(ECSR\)](#)
- 2025 **Best Article Award for Young Scholar: Italian Society of Economic Sociology**
“Interaction of Parental SES with Children’s Genetic Propensity for Cognitive and Noncognitive Skills: No Evidence of the Scarr-Rowe Hypothesis for Educational Outcomes”
- 2021 **RC28 Travel Award (Dronkers Award)**
[ISA RC28: Accumulation and compensation of inequalities, Turku, Finland](#)
- 2019 **Best Poster Presentation Prize**
[4th NEPS Conference, LIfBi, Bamberg, Germany](#)

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed journal articles

- 6) Bernardi F., & **Ghirardi G.** (2025) “Socioeconomic status, genotype, and the differential effects of parental separation on educational attainment” *Demography*
- 5) **Ghirardi G.** (2025) “The development of body mass index from adolescence to adulthood: A genotype-family socioeconomic status interaction study” *Social Science and Medicine*
- 4) **Ghirardi G.**, & Gioachin F. (2025) “Center-based formal childcare closes gaps, others may widen them: How childcare arrangements shape early educational inequality” *Acta Sociologica*
- 3) **Ghirardi G.**, & Bernardi F. (2025) “Compensating or boosting genetic propensities? Gene-family socioeconomic status interactions by educational outcome selectivity” *Social Science Research*
- 2) **Ghirardi G.**, Gil-Hernández C., Bernardi F., van Bergen E., & Demange P., (2024) “Interaction of parental SES with children’s genetic propensity for cognitive and noncognitive skills: No evidence of the Scarr-Rowe hypothesis for educational outcomes” *Research in Social Stratification and Mobility*
- ★ *Best Article Award for Young Scholar, Italian Society of Economic Sociology (SISEC), 2025*
- 1) **Ghirardi G.**, Baier T., Kleinert C., Triventi M., (2022) “Is early formal childcare an equalizer? How attending childcare and education centres affects children’s cognitive and socio-emotional skills in Germany” *European Sociological Review*

Chapters

- Stienstra, Kim, & **Ghirardi, G.**, (2026) “Genetics of Education: From Research to Policy to Improve Educational Performance and Equality”. Forthcoming in: *The Biological Turn in Education Policy:*

Navigating Minds eds. Mattei, Kyriazi, Ydesen, Stieger

Comments and commentaries

Ghirardi G., Van Hootegem, A. & Harden. K. P. (2026) “Embryo screening and the new reproductive divide” *Nature Human Behaviour*

Van Hootegem, A. & **Ghirardi G.** (2025) “Embryo selection based on polygenic prediction risks reinforcing social inequality” *Fertility and Sterility*

WORKING IN PROGRESS & UNDER REVIEW

Ghirardi G. & Ferrara, A. “Social media use, genotype and adolescent mental health: A social push pattern among girls” (R&R *Scientific Reports*)

Ghirardi G. & Gioachin, F. “Family income volatility and children’s education by income level and genotype” (under review)

Van Hootegem, A., Salokangas, H., **Ghirardi, G.**, Dobewall, H., Jernstöm, L., & Vaalavuo, M. “Do genes modify earnings trajectories following job loss? Gene-environment interactions with endogenous and exogenous forms of job loss” (under review)

Cozzani, M., **Ghirardi, G.**, & Ferrara, A. “Abortion rates and birth outcomes: evidence from Spain” (under review)

Bernardi, F., Ferrara, A., **Ghirardi G.** “Unequal luck: chance as a mechanism of educational inequality” (working in progress)

Stienstra, K., & **Ghirardi, G.** Cumulative Family Adversity and Gene–Environment Interactions in Child Development (working in progress)

TEACHING AND SUPERVISION

Fall 2026 **Lecturer** (MA Level)
Course: Trends and Determinants of Educational Inequality
Free University, Berlin

January 2025 **Guest Lecturer** (PhD Level)
Course: Sociogenomics
Winter School on Inequality and Social Welfare Theory

2023; 2024; 2025 **Guest Lecturer** (MA Level)
Course: Sociogenomics
University of Bologna, Department of Statistical Sciences
Thesis Co-supervisor

2024 - 2025 Fatema Khan: MA level (Department of Statistical Sciences, UNIBO)

October 2019 - March 2020 **TA** (BA level)
Course: Quantitative Methods in Sociology
Course: Quantitative Methods in International Studies
University of Trento, Department of Sociology

ACADEMIC SERVICE

- Reviewer** *Child Development, European Societies, European Sociological Review, Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry Advances, Infant and Child Development, Nature Communications, Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, PNAS Nexus, Research in Social Stratification and Mobility, Social Forces, Social Science & Medicine (Medical Sociology), Social Science & Medicine (Social Epidemiology), Sociological Science, Sociology of Education, SSM Population Health*
- April 2024 **Co-organizer workshop on Sociogenomics**
European University Institute (with Kim Stienstra)
- Feb 2024 **Co-organizer workshop on Sociogenomics**
University of Oslo (with Arno van Hootegem, Ruth Eva Jørgensen, Torkild Hovde Lyngstad, Karri Silventoinen)
- 2021 - 2022 **Co-organizer working group and seminars at EUI**
CLIC, DISTANT CLIC and Inequality Working Group (IWG)
Sponsors: Fabrizio Bernardi, Juho Härkönen

CONFERENCES

- 2026 **ESSGN, EPC*, ECSR Annual Conference**
Bologna (IT), Bologna (IT), Dublin (IRL)
- 2025 **AlpPop, RC28 Spring Meeting, PAA Annual Conference, ESSGN*, PopDays**
La Thuile (IT), Milan (IT), Washington DC (US), Bristol (UK), Cagliari (IT)
- 2024 **SISEC, BGA, ECSR Annual Conference**
Cagliari (IT), London (UK), Barcelona (ES)
- 2023 **AlpPop, SISEC, ESSGN, RC28 Spring Meeting, ECSR Annual Conference, LIVES**
La Thuile (IT), Brescia (IT), Bologna (IT), Paris (FR), Prague (CS), Losanna (CH)
- 2022 **PAA Annual Conference, RC28 Spring Meeting, ECSR Annual Conference, PopFest**
Atlanta (US), London (UK), Amsterdam (NL), Florence (ITA)
ESSGN, SISEC
Bologna (IT)
- 2021 **ISA RC28 Spring Meeting**
Turku (FI) - Online
- 2019 **4th NEPS Conference***
Bamberg (DE)

* Poster presentation

No symbol: Oral presentation

INVITED TALKS

- 2025 **Interactions between childhood socioeconomic status and genotype in educational outcomes: A novel theoretical typology and meta-analysis of molecular genetic studies**
Max Planck Research Group Biosocial, Berlin (online)
- 2024 **Socioeconomic status, genes, and the differential effects of parental separation on educational attainment**
QSS CLS Seminar Series, UCL, London
- 2024 **Re-theorizing sociogenomics research on the gene-by-family socioeconomic status (GxSES) interaction for educational attainment**
University of Trento, Euregio Seminar
- 2023 **Re-theorizing sociogenomics research on the gene-by-family socioeconomic status (GxSES) interaction for educational attainment**

- Sociogenomics workshop, Finnish Institute for Health and Welfare, Helsinki
- 2022 **Do high-SES parents compensate for genetic risk for poor educational achievement in offspring?**
VU University Amsterdam
- 2022 **Re-theorizing sociogenomics research on the gene-by-family socioeconomic status (GxSES) interaction for educational attainment**
ECSR's Network Workshop, European University Institute, Florence

ADDITIONAL TRAININGS

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| August 22 - 26 , 2022 | Introduction to Sociogenomics
University of Oslo (Felix Trops) |
| July 5 - 16, 2021 | Nature and Nurture: Twin Research and Human Genetics
VU Amsterdam Summer School |
| October 16 - December 21, 2020 | Introduction to Social Science Genetics
The Silver Beach Institute (Robbee Wedow, and Andrew Grotzinger) |
| May 14 - 15, 2019 | Panel Data Analysis
GESIS Training Course in Mannheim (Josef Brüderl) |

REFEREES

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Nicola Barban

Full Professor of Demography
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